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Published by

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Estimated reading time

4 min

Added on

2025-08-21

Address

<https://www.theguardian.com/tv-and-radio/2025/aug/21/hostage-review-suranne-jones-prime-minister-netflix-drama>

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You know how it is. One moment you're on a romantic walk in the woods with your saintly, supportive husband as he convinces you to stand for election as prime minister, the next you *are* that prime minister (with the shorter but still flattering haircut to prove it). You're knee-deep in a cancer drug supply crisis and about to meet with the French president who alone can solve your problem, when news arrives that your saintly, supportive husband – who is, of course, a doctor with Doctors Without Borders – and his team have been abducted by unknown terrorists in French Guiana. What is a [Suranne Jones](#) with a Netflix budget behind her to do?

That is the set-up from which five punchy hours – Hostage fully swerves the curse of streamer-bloat – of great, globetrotting fun proceeds. Jones is the no-nonsense (in a good way, not a Thatcher way) politician-turned-PM Abigail Dalton; [Julie Delpy](#) is the icy president and master strategist Vivienne Toussaint; and Ashley Thomas is Dr Alex Anderson, Dalton's blameless and soon deeply traumatised husband. Before news of the kidnappings arrives, Dalton is hoping to cut a deal with Toussaint that will involve the UK taking in a boatful of Ebola-ravaged refugees that were refused entry at Calais in return for France giving the UK a large amount of lifesaving medicine. Deux political crises averted with one stone, you see. Then the terrorists step in and demand as their ransom Dalton's resignation by 1pm the next day.

I should add that also in the mix are: Abigail and Alex's semi-stroppy daughter Sylvie (Isobel Akuwudike) and Abigail's dying father Max (James Cosmo), both of whom are strongly of the opinion that she should resign and bring Alex home; private secretary Kofi Adomako (Lucian Msamati), an appointee of the previous government and as yet unsure of his new boss's fitness for purpose; Adrienne Pelletier (Jehnnny Beth), the ice queen's warmer and surely trustworthy assistant; and last but not decidedly not least, Toussaint's stepson Matheo (Corey Mylchreest), who deplores his stepmother's political shift to the right, and his new girlfriend Saskia (Sophie Robertson). Think of them as a quiverfull of arrows ready to be fired the moment we need another plot twist, red herring, complication, revelation or downright treachery, and always landing on target. Offshore accounts, leaks, misplaced and well-placed loyalties abound, with ever-changing political considerations and their ramifications woven credibly in.

Oh, and did I mention that Dalton is considered to have "gutted the military" to fund her promises to fix the NHS? Though I'm sure this won't have repercussions if and when she needs their help to rescue her husband and his equally saintly, supportive team.

The first rescue mission, however, is by the French because it is their territory. Alas, it is aborted at the last minute when Toussaint receives a very effective blackmail video that threatens her leadership and would, if she were ousted, leave the way clear for a truly fascistic candidate to stand, which is what her apparent pandering to the right-wing has been designed to deflect. Hidden depths, you see, and subtleties. Hostage onion-skins its episodes very nicely.

It's a rollicking, propulsive and compulsive yarn that also manages to give two great parts to two women of a certain age then leaves them to get on with it as characters rather than symbols. There is perhaps a little too much of Dalton kicking off her high heels in relief every time she's alone, but other than that the two leaders are as unremarkably female as the usual players would be unremarkably male. Of course, this shouldn't still be rare, but it is, and feels refreshing and worthy of note.

As losses mount, the question of how much a leader should be expected to sacrifice for her country comes under greater scrutiny. Does there come a point when you have to give in to terrorists? How do you appraise a concept like the greater good, which has become so emptied of meaning in modern times? And what if the great British public has been baying for your blood beforehand? And the sympathy they have for your predicament lasts no longer than the next viral video showing the death or suffering of an individual unable to procure the drugs they need?

Everyone is terrific in this, and the budget is well spent on location shoots in French Guiana (or somewhere very like it), with Jones doing her usual sterling work as an everywoman in extraordinary circumstances. Or at least everywoman as prime minister in extraordinary circumstances. I do find myself occasionally wishing that she would treat herself and us to a comedy – or something with a comic aspect – more often, but when the dramas are this much fast, furious, intelligent fun, I suppose we shouldn't ask for more.

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